

After the End

Book I:

Opening Shots

Chapter 1: Abandon All Hope

Part 1: A Story Told Many Times Before

On the 88th day after the end of the world a man falls.

The last days have not been kind to him. He chokes on his own blood as he falls. The fluids that don't reach his collapsing lungs leak fast and freely from the gaping gashes that riddle his form. Many of his bones are broken, many of his organs torn to shreds. Pain courses through every nerve in his body; more than he can bear. His vision blurs, and his consciousness fades in and out.

In his moments of lucidity his thoughts are frantic, a desperate panic for survival and a hollow rage. In his panic to survive thinks about the holes in his body and how they can be patched. These thoughts race for solutions to unsolvable problems refusing to accept the certainty of his fate. In this hollow rage he feels cheated. He survived for this long, this can't be how it ends.

But it is. This part of him knows it even if he refuses to acknowledge it in anything other than a blunted fury.

From the blood loss or the build-up of fluid; from the collapsing of his lungs or the damage yet to come when what's left of him breaks as he lands, it is a simple fact that in a few short moments this man will be dead.

This man carries a story with him as he falls.

He carries the story of what brought him to the roof of the building he now falls from. The story of the cause behind his fall, and the story of wounds sure to claim his life. If you go back further they're the story of the end, as seen by this man. The short sprints of frantic violence and the long slow march into all consuming apathy that brought the world and this man to the state they are in today. Even further you'd find a mundane story, a boring one some might even say of a normal man living a normal life drought with normal problems never imagining he'd met his end so soon or so violently.

All together his tale is a tragic one, filled with loss, desperation and a harsh struggle for survival. At the center of it lie a fool's dreams of heroism and grandeur. Perhaps in another world, his story could have been everything he wanted to imagine it could be. A few different choices and a bit more luck and maybe his name would have been known for generations as one of the great people who stood strong in the face of the darkest of days.

But that will not come to pass. Today is the day where his luck ran out, and so today is that day that his story comes to an end. No tales will be told of his daring exploits. No epic poems will be told of his tragedy. All he has to himself in these final moments are the delirious thoughts of a pain-riddled mind.

Regrets and could-have-beens.

It is a story that has been told many times before in the days after the end of the world.

Part 2: Introductions

This is not the story of the dying man. He has a part to play in the story yet to come, in his own way, but he had his chance and it slipped away. Besides this is a story that stretches far beyond one man. This is a story about the end of a great many things, and more importantly what happens after; the beginning of a great many more.

Now there's one thing you'll need before this story can really begin. It's a bit of a formality but it feels better to get it out of the way now as to avoid any unwelcome disruptions later. I want to use your imagination, if you've gotten this far I'm sure you have one. In your mind I'd like you to conjure up the essence of a worm, that isn't quite a worm. Don't worry I believe in you. Now this not quite worm, in its glossy, bulbous, segmented form is going to be about the size of a horse for one, wrapped in armour like a beetle. I imagine you're starting to see the ways it differs from an ordinary worm. It's got a face like a spider, two of them in fact, one on either end of its twisted body with meaty grey mandibles and six beady black eyes. It's got legs too, in a very unwormly fashion, forty eight of them to be exact, each a frightening appendage of grainy muscle tipped with three fingers as sharp as the tip of a spear.

Have you got an image in your head now? Good. You did it wrong. I'm sorry, I know I praised your imagination before but I hate to tell you it's insufficient. You, like all of us, are only capable of imagining in terms of things you've seen—in terms of worms and horses and spiders and this thing that you're imagining is none of those. It is alien, something not of this world, and thus utterly beyond your mind's power to conceive of, resulting in the amalgamation of an abomination that you've thought up for us. But the image you have in your head right now is good enough. You'll be needing it very soon, perhaps you've already guessed why being as clever as you are. Either way with that out of the way the story can truly begin.

The 78th day after the end of the world begins with introductions.

“The replacements are here.”

A woman of a youthful face and a hard demeanor addresses the seven occupants of a small canvas tent, four weary looking escorts at her back.

The replacements.

“Are we replacements for you or are you replacements for us?”

One of the escorts, a man with a lanky, wiry form, speaks up from behind her. One of the tent dwellers replies, a mousy looking kid barely old enough to drink with dirty blond hair bearing a striking resemblance to the girl who escorted the new arrivals in.

“It’s our tent so I think we’re the ones who... sorry.”

He stops when he realises he’s earned an annoyed look from some of the others.

“It was a bad joke. I’m Aman.”

The wiry man reaches out a hand to the boy, who nervously accepts it.

“Nicholas.”

“I’m Hanna.”

Another one of the replacements speaks up, the shortest among them of a stout build. With her she carries a small, heavily water damaged cardboard box.

“Do we just take any bunk?”

“The one up here is mine. Anything else that’s empty is all yours.”

The woman who led them in replies. Hanna shuffles towards an empty hammock awkwardly in the middle of the tent as she shuffles through the contents of her box.

“I don’t know what you have for supplies, I took everything I could from our old tent. We had a blanket, about a year’s worth of tampons and a mostly used up first aid kit.”

“We’re actually almost out of... well all of those.”

A taller girl with a head full of matted curls responds to her.

“If you’re willing to share. I’m Alex by the way.”

Hanna shrugs at her in response.

“Be my guest.”

The last two of the new arrivals to the tent, creep their way in with hesitant steps. One a barrel-chested man with a careful lumbering gait, the other a smaller, scrawnier man with a slight limp to his gait.

“Are these two free?”

The smaller man gestures to a stacked pair of bunks towards the back, moving towards them when he’s met with no protest.

“I’m Daniel. This is my husband, Jonathan.”

Jonathan’s eyes scan the room for a moment. He’d caught a flinch from the woman who brought him in when they’d first been introduced. Part of him regretted looking in the first place but he supposed he’d rather know sooner than later if there was going to be a problem. No one else pays them any mind.

A brief silence falls off the room as the new arrivals settle in. Aman, being the first to run out of things with which to make himself look busy casts a curious, almost expectant eye towards the others who’ve yet to speak up. Most don’t meet his gaze, until Alex speaks up, the silence having gone on long enough to feel awkward.

“This is Jasmine, that’s Nicole.”

She points first to the surly looking woman in the bunk below her own, one who’d met Aman’s curious glancing but electing not to speak for herself. She points next to the woman across from her, who’d remained largely despondent since the replacement’s arrival.

“Dominic.”

Another man within the tent speaks up, following the example of Alex. He has the broad build of a man once powerful, reduced by the lack of upkeep in the hard days of late. A few pairs of eyes now turn to the last two who’ve yet to speak up. A man and a woman, the latter unrestfully sleeping in a bunk in the far corner, a congested wheeze coming out of her with every breath. The man sits next to her, his head across for hers, his body heats his only too to help fight her fever. After a pause as he notices the prying eyes, he mutters out to the others.

“I’m Liam. This is Eve.”

“Is she okay?”

Hanna asks, laying her box next to a similar storage unit beneath Nicole’s hammock.

“She needs rest.”

Liam replies wearily.

“Unless you have medicine.”

“Anti-septic is the best I have. If it’s an infection it might do some good, but even at that...”

She trails off, watching Liam’s face fall at her the word “infection.” He knows what’s happening. They all do, but saying it out loud just makes it all the more undeniable. Breaking the tension, Tasha addresses the tent.

“You have about five more minutes before we’re off to the fence.”

Tasha is the name of the woman who brought the replacements in, acting as something of an official unofficial leader among this motley crew. She won’t introduce herself in this scene, that would be redundant since everyone already knows her name. Not knowing her name will do you all that much good. Like the residents of this tent both new and old have just been bombarded by an assortment of new faces and names, none of which you have much of any incentive to care about. You can’t be expected to internalize them all. You’ll do I imagine something similar to what they themselves are doing, picking favorites from the memorable ones. The ones you think will live the longest.

In the five minutes they had, Alex put a firm hand on Nicole’s shoulder who rose to her feet, looking weakly to the others. Liam softly roused his wife who blinked into consciousness.

“It’s just a little way. You can rest when we get there.”

With their time expired, the group of twelve march out of their tent, some with surer steps than others. Their weary eyes meet the blinding amber dawn as they shuffled across the rubbled strew asphalt, passing tents just like theirs and groups just like theirs, some offering pitied glances as their paths crossed others simply staring at the ground in their march.

Their paths also cross with creatures much less pitiable to their eyes and yours. Monstrous things, incomprehensible yet frighteningly mundane crawling their way through the corridors between tents like grotesque overgrown pillbugs. They know them by many names: “Crawlers,” “Invaders,” or “Bugs.” *Stella Dicaput* is what the scientist called them but there aren’t many of those still around.

Arriving at their destination—a small depot at the northern edge of the camp—a pair of these creatures join the weary travelers. These creatures too have names, although none in the group know them. They’ve given them their own, “Ten-Eye” for the one with scarring across

two of its beady black light receptors and “Scratch” for the one with the smallest of chips in the center of its armored carapace. They pay their new attachees little mind. To them this is nothing new. Their march continues on.

“Have you set up posts before?”

Alex inquired with the replacements, getting a half-hearted nod from Daniel and Jonthan, and a shake from Aman and Hanna.

“We did mostly demolitions. We never went anywhere that didn’t already have them up.”

“I’d imagine it’s not that different. They seem satisfied if we manage to bring six between us on any given trip so if the two of you could manage one that’d be great. Have you ever used a lifeline before?”

Both responded in the negative.

“Plug it into the little socket near the back of your implant before we cross beyond the fence. I can help you if you can’t get it on your own. Make sure you grab a fresh one when we come back to restock, we’re not quite sure how long they last so it’s safer not to push it.”

After a brief moment to load, the group set off under the lead of Ten-Eye, Liam carrying a post all on his own, Eve trailing behind the hi,, her gait closer to a pained shuffle than a march. At the end fence line, marked by the last active post they took but a moment to attach their lifelines before passing beyond the relative safety of the furthest edge of the camp. And thus they set to work.

True to her word, Alex spent the day tutoring the new arrivals of the wiring, activating and raising each post, assisted by a somewhat begrudging Jasmine and a slightly warmer Nicole. It was a hard job but there were certainly harder ones. After two posts worth of pained small talk, Nicole started with a question that had clearly been on her mind since she the replacements arrived.

“In the camp did you ever meet anyone named Kevin?”

“Kevin?”

Aman glanced at Hanna who shrugged at him.

“I don’t think so. We had Kyle on our crew before, well... you can probably guess.”

“Is your whole crew...?”

“Yep. Charge went off too early and brought half a block down on them. The two of us had just started leaving when it happened.”

“I’m sorry.”

Hanna shrugged again.

“I didn’t really know them.”

Aman followed up.

“The other two came from a different tent. If you want you can try asking them about your...?”

“Boyfriend.”

A block away, Jonathan and Daniel helped Liam with his posts. Even sat a short distance away, panting exhausted already from the short march to the fence and the constant standing and looking productive anytime the wandering Scarth got a little too close. She didn’t speak a word the whole time, Liam encouraged her to focus on resting. Without tissues, sleeves long soaked she just coughed onto the pavement, putting as much distance as she dared between her own likely virulent fluids and the others, leaving a growing pile of phlegm in the places which she sat.

They made three treks back to the depot to resupply, each march getting longer and longer as the fence stretched ever further and the weight of their work wore on them. Eve was worn down most of all, though she didn’t touch a post all day. By the time they made their final walk back, Liam had to practically carry her as she leaned on him for support. Upon their return, they feasted upon the meager bowls of flavourless mush left for them in the tent, long gone cold if ever it had been warm. And then each in turn they went to bed. And each in turn woke up to do the exact same thing as the day before.

On the 79th day they were more efficient. Aman and Hanna knew what they were doing, to all’s relief Eve claimed to be feeling better, offering to help where she could. Liam refused, telling her to rest and save her strength, never leaving her side in their rare moments of break.

On the 80th day that efficacy was lost. Eve grew worse again and the group got tired. It was monotonous work. Mind-numbing. Without breaks, without mirth, without any end in sight what rest they had was filled with dreams of yet more work.

On the 81st it was clear they were slipping. Eve was slipping, the poor woman could barely stand and the Bugs were taking notice. Their watches became more frequent, their following distance grew every shorter, ever slip, ever trip, every grunt of pain they were there to

watch, their gaze piercing their claws sharp and their message clear. Before wrapping up for their slowest day Alex made a point of working near Tasha, beyond the earshot of Liam.

“What are we going to do about Eve?”

“What do you mean ‘what are we doing to do?’”

“She’s not getting better, especially not if we keep dragging her out like this.”

“I’m aware.”

“So can you... help?”

“How?”

“I don’t know. You act like you’re in-charge of us, aren’t leaders supposed to have plans?”

“That’s not- They give me orders, I give them to you, that’s the extent of it.”

“Have you tried talking to them?”

“Have you? I haven’t seen you striking up any conversation, maybe because we’ve all seen what happens when you do.”

“Then can we at least let her rest? Bringing her out is hurting her and slowing us down, surely they can see that much.”

“You think Liam would agree to that? Hell do you think she would? We’ve all heard the same rumours.”

“And we don’t know they’re true.”

“And if they are, she’ll be dead. Would you take that risk?”

Alex broke away from the conversation and back to her work, frustration seeping from poise. As Ten-Eye dipped out of view following a check-in, she flinched, half a mind to follow, to do something. Anything. Jasmine caught her tension.

“Don’t.”

“I wasn’t... Someone has to...”

“That won’t do anything. You know that. It isn’t worth dying for.”

“Well then what the fuck are we living for!”

Alex didn’t say the last part out loud. No matter how much she wanted to. All she did that day was the only thing any of them had done for the last days and silently went back to work

On the 82nd day, Eve would not get up. She rose to consciousness when prodded and collapsed just as quickly when left alone. Liam refused to let anyone touch her at first until a stern word from Tasha allowed Nicole to get close.

“Her fever’s higher than it’s ever been. Her pulse is... slow.”

Not quite three years of biomedical degree making the closest thing the crew had to a doctor.

“Is there anything we can do?”

Nicole just looked from Liam to his wife with all the pity she had left. They all knew the answer to that question.

“I could carry her.”

“That won’t go well. They’ve already been eyeing her when she stumbles.”

“If we leave her behind that’s it.”

“We don’t know that.”

“Yeah we do.”

Most eyes turned to Hanna following her statement. For her part she looks a little startled not expecting such an onslaught of accusatory gazes.

“Do you really not... Two days before we got transferred our crew got his leg blown off. We tried to patch him up, and got him limping back to the tent. He couldn’t stand, let alone work, so the next morning we just went to work without him. Came back that night and there wasn’t a trace of him.”

“So you don’t know that he died.”

“What else do you think happened? They sent him off to a lovely countryside retirement?”

A silence fell for a moment after that.

“So we take her with us and they probably kill her, or we leave her here and they probably kill her.”

“Liam?”

He didn’t make eye contact with any of them, but everyone could see tears welling up.

“For fuck sake, your treating her she’s a dog.”

“What do you want us to do?”

“I can’t-”

“We leave her and we go.”

Tasha put an end to the argument, speaking above the others with forceful authority. No one dared challenge it, no one really wanted to.

“There’s nothing more we can do, no one’s wasting their strength carrying her with us.”

Very few words were spoken on the work day that followed. No one made eye contact with Liam, and in turn he made no motions to engage with anyone, following directions when they were given to him, sulking in the moments they weren’t. His hands shook as they worked, his whole body trembled though the day was unusually warm. More than once he dropped his post, earning an irate glance from Scratch. When the day was done and they marched home his breath was bated, the only sound they heard from him was a whimper when they returned to find the tent empty.

On the 83rd day, Liam once again didn’t speak a word to anyone. In turn no one spoke a word to him. At the depot as the others stopped to load up on supplies, he kept on marching forward. As his destination became clear, Nicole broke the silence.

“Liam!”

He paused for just a moment but didn't turn back. Some looked away, others stared on with a morbid resolution. They'd all seen this happen before. The Bugs offered an almost bemused glance. They've seen this before too, they know escaping isn't the goal. They know damn well how far he'll get. Those who chose only to listen hear the horribly familiar pop. Those who watch see him fall limply to the ground, a faint trail of smoke from his implant. Dead, not a step beyond the range of the fence.

Liam Kamsky carries a story with him as he dies.

He carries a story of young lovers, drawn together as if by fate. A sweeping romance of twists and turns and above all else a happy ending. For a little while at least. He carries the story of a loving husband and a caring father, building a life and a family in a world ever turning upside down. And then his story became a tragedy—one of absolute unfairness, of unfathomable heartbreak in the face of unthinkable loss and the blunted sorrow of watching it all happen, unable to do anything more than weep.

A happy ending feels almost silly to him now. There is no happiness in endings, he thinks to himself as he faces his own. No joy in finality. There are happy beginnings perhaps, at the end of one story but the start of something new. The beginning of adulthood marked the end of youth. When a father passes on, but his sons still carry on to live a life better than he ever could. If he'd had his happy ending sorrow would have come for them sure but never one as like this. Never one so irreconcilably, so impossible to endure. Their story could have been a peaceful one, touched by violence in ways yes but never one as unrelenting as this.

Now that story will never happen. Their stories will never be told, for who is left to tell it? They are survived by no one, they leave nothing behind. The only monument to mark that they'd ever lived all are the two empty beds they'd once filled.

Part 3: Two Empty Beds

On the 83rd day after the end of the world continued as if nothing had changed. After all, very little had changed. Work was done at the same pace it always had been, the renewed speed of ten healthy bodies making up for the lost labour of two. The names of the dead were never spoken aloud again, some looked in silence at the untouched bowl of food left on an empty bed.

On the 84th day, the crew woke to find Jonathan had a bout of congestion. It was mild, yes, but enough to slow him down. Enough for their supervisors to take notice and put everyone one edge. That night he was offered Hanna's blanket, which he gladly accepted.

On the 85th day, he was all better and back to working, and work they did. Their supervision grew tighter, their shift longer and their trips back more frequent. By the end of the day they were exhausted by all definitions of the word.

On the 86th day, they all woke sore. They arose in the morning, worked through the day, bones and muscles screaming as they struggled to maintain any acceptable pace. At night they returned home, consumed their starchy gruel

On the 87th day something finally broke. Someone to be precise. Daniel Lu had never been a strong man. He'd been called weak all his life; been called other things which at the end of the day meant the same thing. He tried not to let them get to his head but he never tried to prove them wrong. He never worked out, never played a sport. He worked his whole life as a barber never lifting anything heavier than a hair dryer. A smarter part of him knows it wouldn't really have made much of a difference, but it always feels better to have something else to blame.

It was their third trip back that day. The sixth post he'd helped raise that day, when he pulled with all the strength he had left and his body simply refused to move. It felt like it happened in slow motion as the post came careening down on top of him. Then very quickly came a sickening crack and a howl of pain as Jonathan rushed to his side. A short assessment had Nicole guess he'd probably fractured his left fibula, not that anyone else really knew what that meant. What they did understand was that he couldn't walk beyond a pained limp and that their supervisors weren't happy with the time they'd already wasted.

"Could we make a crutch or a brace?"

"We need to get back to work or we're going to have bigger problems."

Alex and Tasha began arguing, almost as soon as they arrived at the scene.

"This isn't... we can fix this. Right?"

Several eyes turned to Nicole who just sputtered, unprepared to be thrust into the spotlight

“I...”

“If we can splint it, that’s something right? Find something to support his walking that way at least it won’t get worse.”

Nicole turned relieved to Hanna as she interrupted her, earning a few quizzical glances of her own.

“That’s just basic first aid.”

“What do you need?”

Jonathan wasted no time, very aware of the pressing stares of both Tasha and Crawlers.

“Something long and sturdy? Like a broom handle, ideally more than one. Also something to wrap; fabric, cord, that sort of thing.”

“We don’t have time to go scouring, we’re setting up posts, not scavenging.”

Tasha protested, only to be challenged by Alex once again.

“Then get back to work, we’ll figure this out on our own.”

“You’re going to...”

“Get back to work.”

Tasha conceded, with no small amount of frustration on her face, grabbing her brother and returning to the post they’d briefly abandoned. As she turned to leave, Alex subsumed her position of leadership uncontested.

“Hanna and Nicole, stay with Daniel and try to look busy. Jonathan goes hunting and stays within earshot. Everyone back to work, but holler if the bugs start heading towards him.”

Instructions were given and the crew followed. It took three trips to find what was needed, slipping into the long abandoned residence that surrounded them, pushing the limits of the unspoken perimeter permitted by their watchers. The bugs weren’t thrilled with their actions, that much was clear. They also weren’t interested in killing able-bodied workers for the extent they tested their limits. Not yet at the very least.

The brace they constructed was shabby to say the least, held together quite literally by duct tape and hope. Daneil still winced with every step, though he tried not to show it, showering the others with thanks, assuring them their efforts weren't in vain, even if they all knew they were. They'd staved off disaster for a day, kept Daniel on his feet for a few more or so they hoped. But there were many more days to come. Many more disasters to come. They'd kept on living for one more day but how many more days did they have left?

The 88th day after the end of the world, began like any other. The crew rose in the morning, Daniel limping and pained but moving. It continued like any other until the end of the end of their second trip of the day. Their work was often done in silence, their footsteps, breaths and groans carrying down empty city streets. Other noises would come, the sickening pop of a firing implant, the reverberating bang of a demolished building, but they were few and more often than not expected. This is to say, when a gunshot echoes across the quiet sky people notice.

They turn, first to each other before another, louder shot rings across the sky. And then another. And then voices. Muffled to a point of incoherence no amount of distance can mask the panic carried within them.

“What’s going on?”

Nicolas speaks first, not really expecting his question to be answered. None of them know what’s going on, they haven’t for a while, it just feels better to say it out loud. They wait breathlessly as the voices get closer, eyes darting frantically between each other, the bugs and the walls around them.

“There!”

Jonathan is the first to see something, pointing down an alleyway leading into a townhouse complex. A flash of movement is all they see, two humanoid forms moving too quickly to make out much more than that. Suddenly the crawlers—their dutiful, attentive attendants—take off after the running pair.

“Get back!”

Tasha yells to everyone, an arm flying around her brother as she and others instinctively retreat further from the complex. The forms of more bugs follow in the path of the two humans and the gunshots get louder. Without warning, a figure bursts into the street not twenty meters ahead of them. Covered from head to toe in dark body armour, they spare a second glance at the crew before taking off towards a building across the street before any have a chance to act. As if on cue, following the sudden appearance and disappearance of their partner, the second of the two runners appears as if from thin air.

On the 88th day after the end of the world, a man's life comes to a violent end

The moment his body hits the ground, his head slams into pavement and his brain into the side of his skull bringing his life to a swift if painful conclusion.

The End.

For him at the very least. Sprawled across the earth, blood seeping into the cracks in the sidewalk he landed on, amounting to little more than nothing in the grand scheme of everything. This is the end of a story, but it is not the end of this story. This is the end of the world as we know it, but it is not the end of the world.

This is the story of what happens after. The beginning of something new.